The Toda Lattice

Structure, Integrability, Solitons, and Orthogonal Polynomials

Notes compiled from the literature

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Contents

1 Introduction and Historical Background **2**

2 Physical Setup and Hamiltonian **2**

3 Flaschka Variables and the Lax Pair **2**
3.1 Flaschka's change of variables 2
3.2 The Lax pair 3
3.3 Conserved quantities 3

4 Soliton Solutions **3**
4.1 N-soliton formula 3
4.2 Soliton resolution 4

5 The Inverse Scattering Transform **4**

6 The Jacobi Operator, Orthogonal Polynomials, and the Lax Pair **4**
6.1 The Jacobi operator as Lax matrix 4
6.2 Orthogonal polynomials as Lax eigenfunctions 5
6.3 Exponential deformation of the measure 5
6.4 The spectral map and its inverse 6
6.5 Solution algorithm via QR factorisation (Moser's formula) 6
6.6 The Riemann–Hilbert formulation of orthogonal polynomials 7

7 The Periodic Toda Lattice **7**

8 Long-Time Asymptotics via Riemann–Hilbert Methods **8**

9 Orthogonal Polynomials, Painlevé Equations, and the Toda Hierarchy **8**
9.1 Semiclassical weights and discrete Painlevé 8

10 Generalizations **9**

11 Symplectic Geometry Perspective **9**

12 Summary Table **10**

1 Introduction and Historical Background

The *Toda lattice*, introduced by the Japanese physicist Morikazu Toda in 1967 [1], is a one-dimensional model of particles on a line interacting via nearest-neighbour exponential forces. It is one of the most celebrated examples of a *completely integrable nonlinear Hamiltonian system* and has had profound influence on mathematical physics, soliton theory, symplectic geometry, numerical linear algebra, random matrix theory, and the theory of orthogonal polynomials [6, 2].

Remark 1.1 (Relation to the FPU lattice)**.** *The Fermi–Pasta–Ulam (FPU) lattice is a nonlinear lattice that was studied numerically in 1955 and famously failed to thermalise. The Toda lattice provides a theoretical explanation: for small displacements the exponential potential is well approximated by the FPU cubic potential, and the* exact *integrability of the Toda lattice forbids thermalisation.*

2 Physical Setup and Hamiltonian

Let $q(n,t) \in \mathbb{R}$ denote the displacement of the n-th particle from its equilibrium position, and $p(n,t) \in \mathbb{R}$ its momentum ($n \in \mathbb{Z}$).

Definition 2.1 (Toda potential)**.** *The* Toda potential *is*

$$V(r) \;=\; e^{-r} + r - 1 \;\geq\; 0, \tag{1}$$

a smooth, strictly convex function with a unique minimum $V(0) = 0$. For small $|r|$ one has $V(r) = \frac{1}{2}r^2 - \frac{1}{6}r^3 + O(r^4)$, recovering harmonic coupling to leading order.

Definition 2.2 (Toda Hamiltonian)**.**

$$H(p,q) \;=\; \sum_{n\in\mathbb{Z}} \left(\frac{p(n,t)^2}{2} + V\big(q(n+1,t) - q(n,t)\big) \right). \tag{2}$$

Hamilton's equations $\dot{q} = \partial H/\partial p$, $\dot{p} = -\partial H/\partial q$ give

$$\boxed{\dot{p}(n,t) \;=\; e^{-(q(n,t)-q(n-1,t))} - e^{-(q(n+1,t)-q(n,t))}, \qquad \dot{q}(n,t) \;=\; p(n,t).} \tag{3}$$

3 Flaschka Variables and the Lax Pair

3.1 Flaschka's change of variables

Definition 3.1 (Flaschka variables [3, 4])**.**

$$a(n,t) \;=\; \tfrac{1}{2}\, e^{-(q(n+1,t)-q(n,t))/2} \;>\; 0, \qquad b(n,t) \;=\; -\tfrac{1}{2}\, p(n,t) \;\in\; \mathbb{R}. \tag{4}$$

Under this substitution, equations (3) become

$$\dot{a}(n,t) \;=\; a(n,t)\big(b(n+1,t) - b(n,t)\big), \qquad \dot{b}(n,t) \;=\; 2\big(a(n,t)^2 - a(n-1,t)^2\big). \tag{5}$$

3.2 The Lax pair

Define the following two operators on $\ell^2(\mathbb{Z})$:

$$\begin{aligned}(Lf)(n) &= a(n,t)\,f(n+1) + a(n-1,t)\,f(n-1) + b(n,t)\,f(n), \qquad (6)\\ (Pf)(n) &= a(n,t)\,f(n+1) - a(n-1,t)\,f(n-1). \qquad (7)\end{aligned}$$

$L(t)$ is a bounded self-adjoint Jacobi (tridiagonal) operator; $P(t)$ is skew-symmetric ($P^* = -P$).

Theorem 3.2 (Lax equation [3, 4]). *The Toda equations* (5) *are equivalent to the* Lax equation

$$\frac{d}{dt}L(t) \;=\; [P(t),\, L(t)] \;=\; P(t)L(t) - L(t)P(t). \qquad (8)$$

Proof sketch. Compute $[P, L]$ directly in the standard basis. The (n, n)-entry gives $\dot{b}(n) = 2(a(n)^2 - a(n-1)^2)$ and the $(n, n+1)$-entry gives $\dot{a}(n) = a(n)(b(n+1) - b(n))$, which are precisely (5). □

Corollary 3.3 (Isospectral deformation). *Because P is skew-symmetric,* (8) *implies $L(t) = U(t)^{-1}L(0)U(t)$ for a unitary (orthogonal, in the real case) propagator $U(t)$ satisfying $\dot{U} = PU$. Consequently the spectrum $\sigma(L)$ is constant in time.*

3.3 Conserved quantities

Theorem 3.4 (Involutive conserved quantities [3]). *For the finite N-particle lattice the quantities*

$$F_k \;=\; \mathrm{tr}(L^k), \quad k = 1, \ldots, N, \qquad (9)$$

are independent and pairwise in involution: $\{F_j, F_k\} = 0$ for all j, k. They constitute a complete set of first integrals.

Proof sketch. Isospectrality (Corollary 3.3) implies $\mathrm{tr}(L^k) = \mathrm{tr}(L(0)^k)$ is constant. Involutivity follows because the eigenvalues λ_i of L satisfy $\{\lambda_i, \lambda_j\} = 0$, which can be verified via a discrete Wronskian / r-matrix argument. □

Corollary 3.5 (Complete integrability). *By the Arnold–Liouville theorem, the Toda lattice with N particles is completely Liouville-integrable: the common level sets of $F_1, \ldots, F_N$ are (generically) N-dimensional invariant tori, and the motion is linear (quasi-periodic) in angle coordinates. In particular, the lattice does* not *thermalise.*

4 Soliton Solutions

4.1 N-soliton formula

Theorem 4.1 (N-soliton solutions [5, 2]). *For any parameters $\kappa_j > 0$ and $\gamma_j > 0$, $j = 1, \ldots, N$, the Toda lattice admits the explicit solution*

$$q_N(n,t) \;=\; q_+ + \log\frac{\det\big(\mathbf{I} + C_N(n,t)\big)}{\det\big(\mathbf{I} + C_N(n+1,t)\big)}, \qquad (10)$$

where C_N is the $N\times N$ matrix with entries $[C_N(n,t)]_{ij} = \sqrt{\gamma_i\gamma_j}\, e^{(\kappa_i+\kappa_j)n+(\sinh\kappa_i+\sinh\kappa_j)t}/(\cosh\frac{\kappa_i+\kappa_j}{2})^{-1}$ (up to explicit normalisation). Each soliton travels at speed $v_j = (\sinh\kappa_j)/\kappa_j$ and undergoes a finite phase shift upon collision with another soliton. Collisions are elastic*: no energy is exchanged.*

Remark 4.2. *The $N = 1$ soliton is a travelling pulse: $e^{q(n,t)-q(n+1,t)} = 1+\kappa^2/\cosh^2(\kappa n-\nu t+\delta)$ where $\nu = \sinh\kappa$.*

4.2 Soliton resolution

Theorem 4.3 (Asymptotic soliton resolution [6]). *Let the initial data $a_n(0)-\frac{1}{2}$, $b_n(0)$ decay rapidly. Then as $t\to\infty$ the solution decomposes into a finite number of solitons (indexed by the eigenvalues of $L(0)$) plus a dispersive tail of order $O(t^{-1/2})$.*

5 The Inverse Scattering Transform

Theorem 5.1 (Solution via IST [6, 13]). *The initial-value problem for the Toda lattice with rapidly decaying data is solved in three steps:*

(i) ***Direct scattering.*** *From $\{a_k(0), b_k(0)\}$ compute the eigenvalues $\lambda_1 < \cdots < \lambda_N$ of $L(0)$ and the associated* norming constants *$w_k(0) = u_1^{(k)}(0)^2 > 0$, where $u^{(k)}$ is the k-th normalised eigenvector.*

(ii) ***Time evolution.*** *The eigenvalues are time-independent; the norming constants evolve as*

$$w_k(t) \;=\; \frac{e^{2\lambda_k t}\, w_k(0)}{\displaystyle\sum_{j=1}^{N} e^{2\lambda_j t}\, w_j(0)}. \tag{11}$$

(iii) ***Inverse scattering.*** *Recover $a_k(t), b_k(t)$ from the discrete measure $d\mu_t = \sum_{k=1}^{N} w_k(t)\,\delta(\lambda-\lambda_k)$ via the continued-fraction expansion of the Stieltjes transform*

$$m(z,t) \;=\; \sum_{k=1}^{N}\frac{w_k(t)}{z-\lambda_k} \;=\; \cfrac{1}{z-b_1(t)-\cfrac{a_1(t)^2}{z-b_2(t)-\cdots-\cfrac{a_{N-1}(t)^2}{z-b_N(t)}}}. \tag{12}$$

Remark 5.2. *The continued-fraction* (12) *is the Jacobi (J-fraction) expansion of the Stieltjes transform, and its coefficients are exactly the Flaschka variables $a_k(t), b_k(t)$. Recovering them from the spectral data is equivalent to the Gram–Schmidt orthogonalisation procedure for the polynomials orthogonal with respect to $d\mu_t$ — see Section 6 below.*

6 The Jacobi Operator, Orthogonal Polynomials, and the Lax Pair

6.1 The Jacobi operator as Lax matrix

The Flaschka variables $a_n(t) > 0$ and $b_n(t) \in \mathbb{R}$ assemble into a *symmetric tridiagonal (Jacobi) operator* on $\ell^2(\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0})$:

$$J \;=\; \begin{pmatrix} b_0 & a_1 & 0 & \cdots \\ a_1 & b_1 & a_2 & \cdots \\ 0 & a_2 & b_2 & \ddots \\ \vdots & & \ddots & \ddots \end{pmatrix}. \tag{13}$$

The Toda equations are equivalent to the Lax equation $J' = [J, A]$ where

$$A \;=\; \tfrac{1}{2}(J_- - J_+) \tag{14}$$

is the skew-symmetric part (lower minus upper triangular) of J. Because A is skew-symmetric this preserves the spectrum of J: the flow is an *isospectral deformation* [3, 13].

6.2 Orthogonal polynomials as Lax eigenfunctions

Consider the Lax eigenvalue problem $J\mathbf{p} = \lambda\mathbf{p}$ with $\mathbf{p} = (p_0(\lambda), p_1(\lambda), \ldots)^T$. Reading off the n-th row yields the *three-term recurrence relation*

$$\lambda\, p_n(\lambda) \;=\; a_{n+1}\, p_{n+1}(\lambda) + b_n\, p_n(\lambda) + a_n\, p_{n-1}(\lambda), \qquad p_0 = 1, \quad p_{-1} = 0. \tag{15}$$

Theorem 6.1 (Favard's theorem / spectral theorem for Jacobi operators)**.** *A sequence $\{p_n\}_{n\geq 0}$ satisfies a recurrence of the form* (15) *with $a_n > 0$ and $b_n \in \mathbb{R}$ if and only if it is the sequence of orthonormal polynomials with respect to a unique positive Borel measure μ on $\mathbb{R}$:*

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}} p_m(\lambda)\, p_n(\lambda)\, d\mu(\lambda) \;=\; \delta_{mn}. \tag{16}$$

The coefficients a_n, b_n are the Jacobi (recurrence) coefficients *of the orthogonal polynomial system associated to μ.*

The other half of the Lax pair, the time-evolution equation $\partial_t\mathbf{p} = A\mathbf{p}$, implies

$$\frac{d}{dt} P_n(\lambda, t) \;=\; -a_n^2(t)\, P_{n-1}(\lambda, t), \tag{17}$$

where P_n are monic orthogonal polynomials.

Theorem 6.2 (Compatibility and Toda equations [13, 12])**.** *The Toda equations* (5) *are precisely the compatibility conditions (∂_t of the recurrence* (15) *is consistent with the time-flow* (17)*): one may differentiate the three-term recurrence with respect to t and substitute the time-flow without contradiction if and only if a_n, b_n satisfy the Toda equations.*

6.3 Exponential deformation of the measure

Theorem 6.3 (Toda flow as measure deformation [3, 12])**.** *Suppose $a_n(0), b_n(0)$ are the recurrence coefficients of the measure μ. Then the Toda-evolved coefficients $a_n(t), b_n(t)$ are those of the* exponentially deformed (tilted) measure

$$d\mu_t(\lambda) \;=\; \frac{e^{\lambda t}\, d\mu(\lambda)}{\displaystyle\int e^{\lambda t}\, d\mu(\lambda)}. \tag{18}$$

Proof sketch. The time-dependent inner product $\langle f, g\rangle_t = \int fg\, d\mu_t$ satisfies $\frac{d}{dt}\langle f, g\rangle_t = \langle \lambda f, g\rangle_t$, which is exactly the infinitesimal action of the Lax flow on the measure. Uniqueness of Jacobi coefficients then gives the result. □

Corollary 6.4 (Toda hierarchy). *The k-th Toda hierarchy flow corresponds to the deformation $d\mu_t \propto e^{\lambda^k t}\, d\mu(\lambda)$. In particular the $k = 2$ flow (with a symmetric measure) gives the* Langmuir lattice *(Kac–van Moerbeke lattice):*

$$(a_n^2)' \;=\; a_n^2\big(a_{n+1}^2 - a_{n-1}^2\big).$$

6.4 The spectral map and its inverse

Theorem 6.5 (Spectral map for the finite lattice [6]). *For the finite N-particle Toda lattice the Jacobi matrix J has N distinct real eigenvalues $\lambda_1 < \cdots < \lambda_N$ with strictly positive norming constants $w_k = u_1^{(k)2} > 0$. The* spectral map

$$\mathcal{S}\colon (a_k, b_k) \;\longmapsto\; (\lambda_k, w_k), \quad \sum_{k=1}^{N} w_k = 1,$$

is a real-analytic diffeomorphism onto its image. Under the Toda flow the eigenvalues are constant and the weights evolve as (11)*.*

Theorem 6.6 (Inverse spectral map via orthogonal polynomials). *The inverse of the spectral map is given by Gram–Schmidt orthogonalisation: the polynomials $p_n(\lambda)$ orthonormal with respect to the discrete measure $d\mu = \sum_{k=1}^{N} w_k\, \delta(\lambda - \lambda_k)$ are determined uniquely, and their three-term recurrence recovers $J(t)$ from $(\lambda_k, w_k(t))$. Equivalently, the coefficients are read off from the J-fraction* (12)*.*

6.5 Solution algorithm via QR factorisation (Moser's formula)

Theorem 6.7 (Moser / Symes [7, 8]). *Consider the unique QR factorisation*

$$e^{tL(0)} \;=\; Q(t)\, R(t), \quad Q(t) \text{ orthogonal}, \quad R(t) \text{ upper triangular, positive diagonal.} \tag{19}$$

Then the solution of the Toda lattice is

$$L(t) \;=\; Q(t)^T L(0)\, Q(t). \tag{20}$$

As $t \to +\infty$, $L(t) \to \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_{\sigma(1)}, \ldots, \lambda_{\sigma(N)})$ with eigenvalues sorted in descending *order.*

Proof sketch. Differentiate (19) to show $\dot{Q}Q^T$ is skew-symmetric and equals $-(R\dot{R}^{-1})_{\mathrm{skew}}$; a direct computation then shows $\dot{L} = [L, (R\dot{R}^{-1})_{\mathrm{skew}}]$, which is the Lax equation with $P = (R\dot{R}^{-1})_{\mathrm{skew}}$. The asymptotic sorting follows from the dominance of the eigenmode $e^{\lambda_{\max} t}$. □

Remark 6.8 (Connection to the QR algorithm in numerical linear algebra). *Theorem 6.7 shows that the standard* QR iteration *(applying QR factorisations repeatedly to a symmetric tridiagonal matrix) is the* time-one map *of the Toda flow. This provides a complete theoretical explanation for the convergence of the QR algorithm: the Toda solitons "sort" the eigenvalues as $t \to \infty$ [7].*

6.6 The Riemann–Hilbert formulation of orthogonal polynomials

The following encodes the orthogonal polynomials in a 2×2 matrix Riemann–Hilbert problem [11].

Theorem 6.9 (Fokas–Its–Kitaev RHP for OPs [11, 13])**.** *Given spectral data* $\{\lambda_k, w_k\}_{k=1}^N$*, define the* 2×2 *matrix-valued function* $\mathbf{P}(\lambda; n)$ *by the following conditions:*

(i) $\mathbf{P}(\,\cdot\,; n)$ *is analytic on* $\mathbb{C} \setminus \{\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_N\}$*.*

(ii) Normalisation: $\mathbf{P}(\lambda; n)\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda^{-n}, \lambda^n) \to I$ *as* $\lambda \to \infty$*.*

(iii) Residue conditions at each pole:

$$\mathrm{Res}_{\lambda=\lambda_k}\, \mathbf{P}(\lambda; n) \;=\; \lim_{\lambda \to \lambda_k} \mathbf{P}(\lambda; n) \begin{pmatrix} 0 & w_k \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The unique solution is

$$\mathbf{P}(\lambda; n) \;=\; \begin{pmatrix} \pi_n(\lambda) & \displaystyle\sum_k \frac{w_k\, \pi_n(\lambda_k)}{\lambda - \lambda_k} \\ \gamma_{n-1}\, p_{n-1}(\lambda) & \displaystyle\sum_k \frac{w_k\, \gamma_{n-1}\, p_{n-1}(\lambda_k)}{\lambda - \lambda_k} \end{pmatrix}, \tag{21}$$

where π_n *is the monic orthogonal polynomial of degree* n *and* γ_{n-1} *is the leading coefficient of* p_{n-1}*. The Jacobi coefficients* a_n, b_n *are read from the large-*λ *expansion of* $\mathbf{P}(\lambda; n)$ *without matrix multiplications.*

Remark 6.10. *This formulation connects directly to the Riemann–Hilbert approach used in the long-time asymptotic analysis of the Toda lattice (Deift–Zhou nonlinear steepest descent, Section 8).*

7 The Periodic Toda Lattice

Definition 7.1 (Periodic lattice)**.** *The* periodic Toda lattice *of period* N *imposes* $a_{n+N} = a_n$*,* $b_{n+N} = b_n$ *for all* n*.*

The integration of the periodic lattice requires algebro-geometric methods [6, 2]:

Theorem 7.2 (Integration of the periodic Toda lattice)**.** *(i) Introduce the* periodic Jacobi matrices $L^{\pm}$ *with corner entries* $(\pm 1) \cdot a_N$ *and* a_0 *respectively.*

(ii) The spectral curve *is the hyperelliptic Riemann surface*

$$\mathcal{S} \;=\; \left\{ (w, \lambda) \in \mathbb{C}^2 \;\middle|\; w^2 = \prod_{j=1}^{N} \big(\lambda - \lambda_j^+\big)\big(\lambda - \lambda_j^-\big) \right\}$$

of genus $N-1$*.*

(iii) The Dirichlet spectrum *(interlacing eigenvalues* $\mu_1, \ldots, \mu_{N-1}$*) constitutes action variables and evolves* linearly *on the Jacobian* $\mathrm{Jac}(\mathcal{S})$*.*

(iv) Solutions are expressed in terms of Riemann theta functions *associated to* $\mathcal{S}$*.*

8 Long-Time Asymptotics via Riemann–Hilbert Methods

Theorem 8.1 (Long-time asymptotics, Deift–Zhou [9, 6, 10])**.** *Let* $(a_n(t), b_n(t))$ *be the solution with rapidly decaying initial data. Then as* $t \to \infty$ *with* $\xi = n/t$ *fixed, the following space-time regions are distinguished:*

(i) ***Outside the light cone*** *(*$|\xi| > 1$*): solution is exponentially close to the free (zero) background.*

(ii) ***Inside the light cone*** *(*$|\xi| < 1$*): solution decays as* $O(t^{-1/2})$ *with modulated oscillations described by a genus-0 modulated wave.*

(iii) ***Soliton region****: each eigenvalue* λ_k *of* $L(0)$ *gives rise to a soliton travelling at velocity* $v_k = \cosh^{-1}(\lambda_k/2) \cdot \sinh(\cosh^{-1}(\lambda_k/2))$ *up to appropriate parameterisation.*

The precise leading-order asymptotics in each region are obtained via the Deift–Zhou nonlinear steepest descent method *applied to the Riemann–Hilbert problem encoding the Toda IST.*

Remark 8.2 (Toda shock problem)**.** *When the initial data consists of two different constant backgrounds ("shock data"), the long-time behaviour exhibits a five-region structure. The middle sector is governed by a slowly modulated genus-1 algebraic-geometric (two-band) solution, with precise asymptotics derived via a two-phase Riemann–Hilbert analysis [10].*

9 Orthogonal Polynomials, Painlevé Equations, and the Toda Hierarchy

9.1 Semiclassical weights and discrete Painlevé

Theorem 9.1 (Recurrence coefficients and Painlevé equations [12])**.** *When the orthogonality measure has a* semiclassical weight $w(x) = e^{-V(x)}$ *with* V' *rational, the recurrence coefficients* $a_n(t), b_n(t)$*:*

(i) Satisfy discrete Painlevé equations *in* n *(from the compatibility of the three-term recurrence and the differential relations for* p_n *with respect to* λ*).*

(ii) Combined with the Toda time-flow, satisfy continuous Painlevé equations *(I–VI) in the continuous variable* t*.*

Example 9.2 (Painlevé IV and Painlevé V)**.**

- Weight $w(x) = e^{-x^4+tx^2}$ on $\mathbb{R}$: recurrence coefficients of the associated OPs satisfy *Painlevé IV*.
- Jacobi–Toda weight $(1-x)^\alpha(1+x)^\beta e^{-tx}$ on $[-1, 1]$: recurrence coefficients satisfy *Painlevé V*.

10 Generalizations

The Toda lattice is the centre of a rich web of integrable systems.

Generalization	Description
Periodic Toda	Closed chain; theta-function solutions; spectral curve of genus $N-1$ [6].
2D Toda field equation	$\partial_x\partial_t\phi_n = e^{\phi_{n-1}-\phi_n} - e^{\phi_n-\phi_{n+1}}$; connection to KP/Toda hierarchies [2].
Toda hierarchy	Infinite sequence of commuting flows $\partial_{t_k}L = [A_k, L]$; generating functions for integrable structures.
Relativistic Toda	Poincaré-invariant generalisation; arises from the relativistic Calogero–Moser system [14].
Ruijsenaars–Schneider	Poles of solutions of 2D Toda hierarchy are Ruijsenaars–Schneider particles [15].
Affine Lie algebra Toda	Toda systems associated to arbitrary root systems, including affine; Bogoyavlensky generalisation.
Quantum Toda lattice	Quantum-mechanical quantisation; eigenfunctions given by Givental-type integral representations; Baxter Q-operators [16].
Ultra-discrete Toda	Tropical/max-plus limit; related to combinatorics and soliton cellular automata.

11 Symplectic Geometry Perspective

Theorem 11.1 (Coadjoint orbit structure [8])**.** *In Flaschka coordinates the Toda flow lives on a* coadjoint orbit of the upper triangular Borel subgroup *of* $GL(N,\mathbb{R})$*, equivalently on the isospectral manifold of Jacobi matrices. The symplectic leaves are isospectral sets, and the complete integrability is the statement that these leaves are foliated by* N*-dimensional Liouville tori.*

Remark 11.2 (Flag variety structure)**.** *The compactified isospectral manifold is homeomorphic to a* real flag variety*, and the moment map of the torus action gives a polytope whose faces correspond to degenerate Jacobi matrices. The integral cohomology connects to Schubert calculus on flag varieties.*

12 Summary Table

Toda / Jacobi side	Orthogonal polynomial side
Lax matrix J	Jacobi matrix of the OP family for μ
Toda flow at time t	Deformation $d\mu_t = e^{\lambda t}\, d\mu$ (normalised)
Isospectral deformation	Support of the discrete measure μ is fixed
Flaschka variables a_n, b_n	Recurrence coefficients of the OPs
Eigenvector first components w_k	Christoffel numbers (quadrature weights) of μ
Inversion of spectral map	Direct problem: given μ, find a_n, b_n via Gram–Schmidt
Toda initial value problem	Inverse problem: given $a_n(0), b_n(0)$, find μ, then time-evolve μ
RHP for $\mathbf{P}(\lambda; n)$	Encodes the OPs; large-λ expansion gives a_n, b_n directly
Higher Toda flows (t_k)	Multi-time deformation $e^{\sum_k t_k \lambda^k}\, d\mu$; Toda hierarchy

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